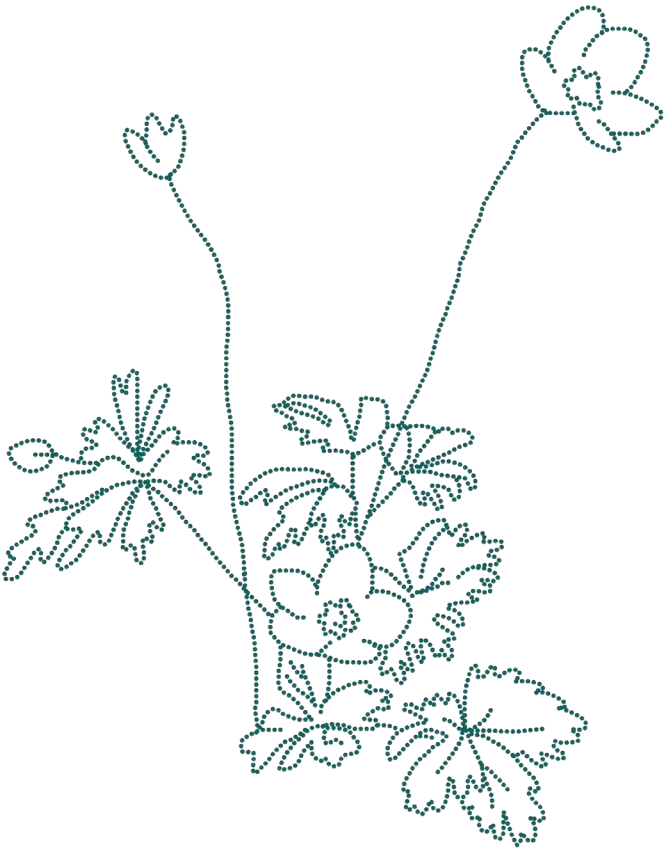
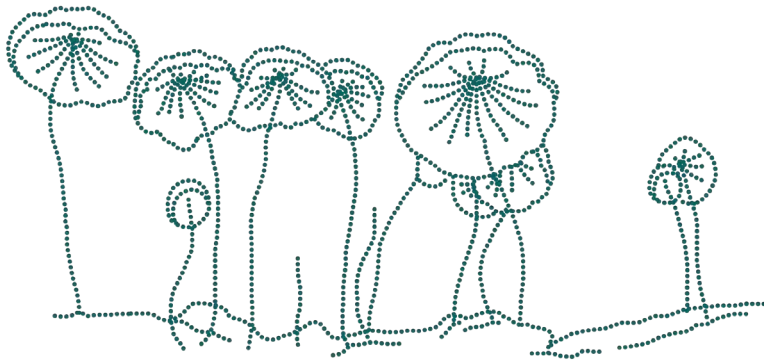
A Community is a Garden



Tools for Artists, Communities, and Institutions

A collective effort organized by Kanyinsola Anifowoshe and Mikki Janower



"We require each other in unexpected collaborations and combinations, in hot compost piles. We become with each other or not at all."

—Donna Haraway,
Staying with the Trouble: Making Kin in the Chthulucene

Hello! Welcome to *A Community is a Garden,* a toolkit for community-driven climate justice through art. Our own communities and artistic spaces have shown us the potential for creative collaborations to build on and strengthen grassroots social change. Through spaces of radical communion and dialogue, artists and communities have forged relationships central to surviving in and transforming our world.

Describing the power and beauty of adaptive relationships, organizer and healer adrienne maree brown writes that "species only survive if they learn to be in community," and that these "critical, deep, and authentic connections [are] a thread that can be tugged for support and resilience"[1]. By deepening, building, and reshaping our relationships to one another and to other elements of the natural world, art has the ability to create unpredictable social transformation.

1. adrienne maree brown, *Emergent Strategy: Shaping Change, Changing Worlds* (AK Press, 2017), 14. Our analysis is deeply indebted to a range of thinkers, activists, and creatives, but in particular to the visions and principles of love and community set forth in this book.

We have also seen that togetherness is not automatically transformative. That profound collaboration must challenge existing understandings of power, access, community, and identity. We feel compelled to ask, how can artists and communities build relationships that serve as grounds for social action?

This line of inquiry lays the groundwork for the toolkit before you: through conversations with visionaries whose work creates frameworks for reimagining our world, we have compiled exercises and prompts for reflection to support collaborations between artists, communities, and institutions. These conversations are not over; we'd love to continue them with you, and we invite you to experiment with, build on, and question the ideas here. You can read and share this PDF at bit.ly/communitygarden.

Yours in community,
Kanyinsola Anifowoshe and Mikki Janower

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Is An Artist an Amplifier?



Ila N. Sheren, PhD., is an art historian, author, and professor at Washington University in St. Louis. Dr. Sheren's research focuses on questions of borders and decolonial theory, whether in the case of the U.S. frontera, environmental crisis in the Global South, or the performative nature of political protest. She teaches courses in new media, activist art, and alternative art practices, as well as surveys of modern and contemporary art.

A Conversation with Ila N. Sheren

MJ: Why should artistic practice play a role in grassroots change? Why privilege art alongside more traditional social initiatives?

IS: That is a question I continually negotiate. There have always been movements to separate art from life, and even artists involved in community organizing tend to fall back on their identities as artists. But this separation allows art to operate in a space of ambiguity that can be productive for raising awareness or upending preconceived beliefs.

Art can also entail immersive sensory experiences with a far more intense emotional impact than unadorned facts. It challenges your mind in different ways.

MJ: In the realm of community engagement, artists and organizers tend to operate in packs. Why such emphasis on collectivity?

IS: In true collective practice, works are built by many voices and filtered through different lenses: collectivism intends to draw on everybody's strengths. This practice reached a fever pitch during the HIV crisis, when you'd see artists subsuming their identities in favor of a greater good. Even outside of collectivism, however, most eco art requires a team. Yet the art world continues to rely on an outdated myth of a singular 'genius', a distinctly colonialist narrative.

MJ: We've spoken previously about how decoloniality, or the rejection of Eurocentric narratives, figures heavily into the collectivist ethos. What does a decolonialized artistic practice look like?

IS: A mark of decolonial work is the inclusion of multiple voices. Postcommodity is a prominent example, centering artists of color and artists from indigenous backgrounds, though they notably lacked female-identifying members.

In practice, perfect decoloniality cannot be achieved—it is a constant process of re-negotiating existing perspectives and hierarchies. And even decolonial work must contend with existing power structures in order to challenge them.

MJ: Is there an example of decolonial practice that stands out to you?

IS: One example is *The Sovereign Forest,* a 2011 installation by Amar Kanwar in collaboration with activist Sudnir Pattnaik and filmmaker Sherna Dastur.



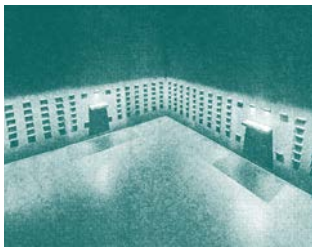


FIG. 1-2 two views of The *Sovereign Forest.*

The exhibition addresses the land rights of native communities in Odisha in response to the UK mining companies who had marked indigenous land for demolition. The artists defer to indigenous knowledge, partnering with local social justice groups. The film segment of their work rejects documentary hierarchies of knowledge; it denies that the viewer is its center.

The Sovereign Forest declines to impose a narrative or to fetishize the violence of the conflict. Instead, it honors alternative ways of thinking about land and belonging. Moreover, the work reflects a long-term commitment by the artists, who maintain a presence in the affected communities.

In true collective practice, works are built by many voices and filtered through different lenses: collectivism intends to draw on everybody's strengths.

MJ: Can you elaborate on the fetishization of violence in works like these?

IS: Depictions of violence can shatter our sense of complacency, but past a point they draw violence onto itself, re-enacting violence upon colonial subjects. On the one hand, who has the right to refuse exposure to violence? When is the refusal of violence a privilege? On the other hand, across the eco art landscape we see many (primarily white, cis, male) artists capitalize on the canon of the 'toxic sublime' with depictions of sulfuric, ravaged landscapes. How do their works mediate between despair and the search for a solution? How do they privilege action and understanding?

MJ: How can artists better address instances of ecological violence?

IS: I tell my students about a Joanna Moll piece titled *DEFOOOOOOOOOOOOOOOOOOOOREST.* The website models CO2 emissions derived from visits to google.com by demonstrating the number of trees required to counteract the damage—about 23 per second. As soon as the site loads, miniature images of trees appear at pace; they fill the screen within seconds.

At the time of its release, the work provided a novel insight: that mitigating the effects of the climate crisis hinged on systemic, not individual, change. It encouraged an informed course of action: holding major corporations accountable.

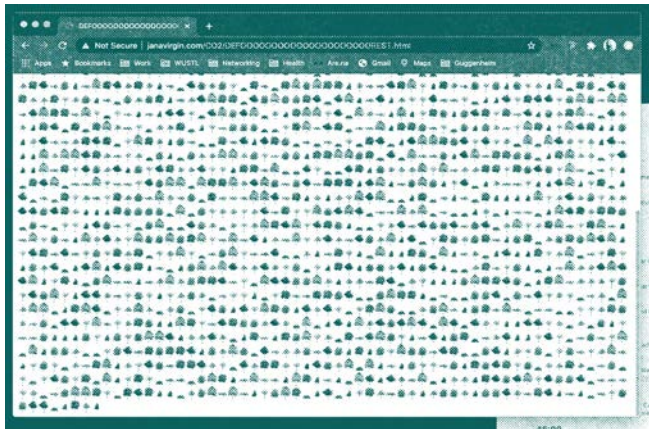


FIG. 3 Joanna Moll visualizes the number of trees required to offset carbon emissions from visits to google.com

MJ: I find it interesting that Moll addresses an ecological issue in the virtual sphere. What role does digital art play in the debate around our physical environment?

IS: An overly simplistic answer is that digital art opens new avenues for communication and access, but this belies the fact that many people lack internet access, that digital works are hard to find amid the constant noise of cyberspace, and that net art is incredibly difficult to preserve. In practice, I find that addressing environmental issues in the virtual sphere strips away the romantic veneer of nature as a remote entity. Digital eco art dematerializes our illusions of the natural world and suggests a truer conception of nature as inextricable from daily life, even for those in urban spaces.

Virtual spaces exist as networks of relations and clicks; they force us to orient ourselves to the world in a different way. This reorientation can be used to strip away existing connotations and de-center the human hand. Digital art collapses binaries: nature and non-nature, human and non-human. This is possible in sited space, but more difficult, especially when existing hierarchies are embodied in a site.

MJ: How might digital art collapse distinctions between human and non-human subjects?

IS: A wonderful example is *Leviathan,* a 2012 work by Verena Caravel and Lucien Castaing-Taylor. The film is a non-narrative account of a commercial fishing excursion. Cameras are mounted on the boat, in the ocean, in the air, and on the laboring bodies of the fishermen; the viewer effectively assumes the role of fish, boat, bird, and laborer. Each perspective is a subject and a storyteller in equal parts.

MJ: Returning to collective action, how can this line of inquiry grant communities greater agency?

IS: What does it mean to grant someone agency? There are many ways to constructively engage with communities. In *Floodnet,* Electronic Disturbance Theatre developed open-access software that allowed anyone to stage virtual sit-ins on government servers: here, we see a tool for of collective empowerment. But when artists sided with activists at Standing Rock, the artists simply acknowledged and amplified existing community structures. There are cases where an artist convenes an initiative or demonstration, but even those should be exercises in honoring existing networks; projecting the voice of a community; or translating it into a new medium. Art should neither overshadow communities nor portray them as helpless: agency over large-scale transformation lies in collectivity, and always has.



FIG. 4–5 two of many non-human perspectives privileged in *Leviathan.*

1

Did anything in this conversation stand out to you? Record your impressions here.

2

What is one element of this conversation that you could carry into your own work?

3

What is one element of this conversation that you disagree with? Why?

Use the blank space below to write, draw, or diagram any remaining thoughts.

4

WORKS CITED

FIG. 1 – 2 Kanwar, Amar, "The Sovereign Forest," film & multimedia installation, 2011, (Amar Kanwar), http://amarkanwar.com/the-sovereign-forest-2012/.

FIG. 3 Moll, Joanna, "DEF0000000000000000000REST," net art, 2016, (Joanna Moll), http://www.janavirgin.com/CO2 /DEF000000 0000000000000000REST.html.

FIG. 4 – 5 Castaing-Taylor, Lucien, and Paravel, Verena, "Leviathan," digital cinema, 2012, (Harvard Sensory Ethnography Lab), http://www.leviathanfilm.org/.

QUESTIONS FOR DISCUSSION

We've spoken previously about decoloniality, or the rejection of Eurocentric narratives in the production of knowledge. How does decoloniality inform your work?

Are you creating a narrative work? If so, who owns the narrative? What perspectives, human or non-human, do you represent?

The Forest as Mediator

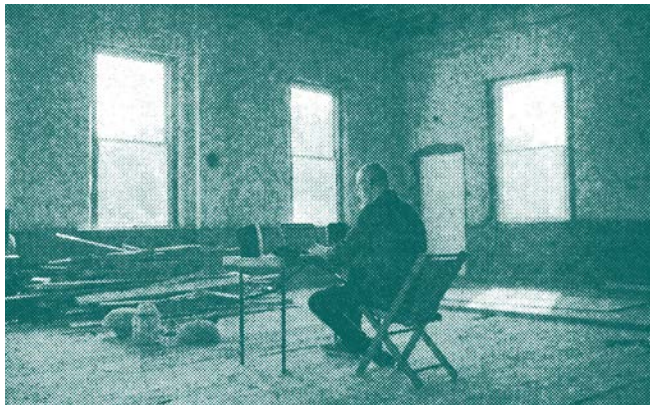


FIG. 6 Harnetty working in Shawnee. Photo: Rava Films

Brian Harnetty and Cheryl Blosser



FIG. 7 Harnetty and group during a silent listening session Photo: Rava Films



FIG. 8 Harnetty and group listening together. Photo: Rava Films

on Radical Commitment to Staying in Place

In Brian Harnetty's *Forest Listening Rooms (FLR),* participants gather to silently listen to the Appalachian forests of Shawnee, Ohio, hear archival recordings of the land's histories, and share their own memories and stories of the forest. Harnetty describes the work as using "listening as a way to have conversations about land use, about private versus public land, and how the future of the land might look."

It is perhaps difficult to imagine the silence that *FLR* participants encounter—the absence of noise that creates space for another kind of presence. Cheryl Blosser, a local historian and *FLR* participant, notes, "It seemed to me that [Harnetty] was being very careful not to influence you too much. He wanted what came out of the conversations to be mostly let in by the silences or the sounds of the woods or the other people. A lot of what he did was to just let us feel and talk about what we did feel and whatever memories those brought out." Blosser's comments highlight that by stepping back rather than stepping in, Harnetty creates space for the forest's sounds and silences to guide the conversations. In *FLR,* land is a form of active life rather than a static background—which Harnetty emphasizes by letting the land's many histories speak.

KA: How would you describe your role as an artist throughout this process?

BH: My touch is pretty light and my process is pretty gentle. If I've been able to add anything, it's the archival part—for example, we visited Robinson's Cave, the birthplace of the United Mine Workers, where different factions of mine labor groups in the late 1880s put their differences aside to create one larger, more powerful union. But that space is also where a different set of miners just a couple of years later conspired to set the mines on fire. We listened to these covert recordings of people talking about finding solidarity with one another and about the fires that still burn under the ground. The place itself is very pretty at the moment, with mitigation efforts and trees growing back from deforestation. So, the participants were able to hold the past and the present together. It really did feel like the trees were acting on us. They were definitely playing an active role in that process of listening.

The more you connect with the historical, cultural, and social contexts of a place, the more connected you feel to that place. This moment of reflection allowed community members who might take the forest for granted to reevaluate their relationships with it; to have a certain pride in the land and want to help protect it.

Harnetty's light touch allows *FLR* to speak what Robin Wall Kimmerer (botanist and member of the Citizen Potawatomi nation) might call the "grammar of animacy." Kimmerer writes that when our language honors the animacy of all life forms—including those that English-speakers are used to describing as inanimate—we are able to come into relationships of reciprocity rather than exploitation. In *FLR*, we see one vision of this—as Harnetty puts it, participants envision a world in which "we could actually help change the place, to heal it, even at the same time as it was changing us."

Through communion with the land, we learn new ways of being in community with each other: as Harnetty observes, "The forest itself becomes a mediator between people that might think differently or have different cultural backgrounds or are even on different parts of the political spectrum. It opens up the conversation so that participants are much more engaged and open with one another. That's the point where something can really change between how people perceive each other." By building connections across lines of difference, the forest provides roots for a community not of superficial unity, but of multifaceted togetherness.

For Harnetty, facilitating this community required him to be open to shifting the conditions of the work in order to reach those who may have not been immediately sympathetic.

KA: How did you work to make *FLR* accessible?

BH: Instead of having public events, I started to do some that were more private. I would go to different residents where they were comfortable and where they had something to show me. I accompanied a hunter to make field recordings at predawn, walking with him through woods he knew very well. He probably wouldn't have come to a session with a lot of other people, but he was more than happy to take me along with him. I found that he was well practiced in walking through the forest quietly and using his listening to aid

the process. I also found that he was sort of an unusual ally. Hunters might have very different views or more conservative views than myself. But they have a really strong sense of public land and protecting those lands. I just saw an opening where people that think differently could actually come together over this shared idea.

Open conditions create openings between people—a light may shine in where the static cracks. The work is dictated not solely by a lead artist, but by a confluence of people and place.

KA: How does FLR relate to other works of art you've seen?

CB: An artist takes what's around him and interprets it—[Harnetty] is letting the people be part of the process in creating the art that they're there as part of. And each time he goes to a site it's going to be different—the people who come will be different; the sounds will be different; the wind will be different.

A lot of what he did was to just let us feel and talk about what we did feel and whatever memories those brought out.

The work then, is not defined by any individual listening session, but by the totality—the returning again and again. In each iteration of *FLR*, Harnetty makes field recordings of the dialogue between participants, and includes fragments of those recordings in subsequent listening sessions. He explains, "We're creating a kind of sound map of the places, but also of the people that live there. Even if someone only attended one listening session, their voices would still be heard by future participants. Each time the project had a momentum spiraling outward. We learned that we needed to spend time doing this, and to keep coming back again and again instead of just doing it once. When you do it many times over a long period of time, not only the listening experience deepens, but ultimately the relationships deepen as well.

KA: Could you speak more about the role of relationships in the work?



FIG. 9 Harnetty listening with participants at the XX Mine in the Wayne National Forest. Photo: William Randal





FIG. 10 – 11 image of Shawnee, Ohio. Photos: Jon Johnson.

FIG. 12 Harnetty listening with children in the Wayne National Forest. Photo: Kevin Dawson



BH: How can you keep coming back when you have different ideologies? And how do you keep coming back to one another—to that common ground between you? These are particularly valuable questions in communities where I might be considered an outsider or I might have very different viewpoints. But at the same time, the simple act of me coming back again and again so that we might have a disagreement over coffee, but then at the end of it, I'd say, 'Well, I'll see you again next week,' means that there is a long term trust that's being built up. It's exactly the opposite of our political conversations today, which are not really based on listening or paying attention to another person, but ticking through one's bullet points. So, it's very slow and not very practical.

> We learned that we needed to spend time doing this, and to keep coming back again and again instead of just doing it once. When you do it many times over a long period of time, not only the listening experience deepens, but ultimately the relationships deepen as well.

I think that there are many other wonderful projects out there that are designed to be short term: coming in as an artist and engaging with the community for a while. But this is a little bit different and a little bit more impractical because it's really hard to focus on one particular place over 10 years or 20 years or a lifetime even. And yet I keep trying to do that. It's not always very easy. And every time that I'm tempted to try to move away, I double down on finding a way to keep engaging. Ironically, it has something to offer that I

don't know if I could find anywhere else: a radical commitment to staying in place and working with a community over a long period of time. With more experience, I've seen the evolution of relationships between people and my own personal relationship with the land.

Brian Harnetty is an interdisciplinary artist using sound and listening to foster social change. His creative projects are grounded in Appalachian Ohio, blending archival recordings of oral histories and field recordings of place, along with contemporary listening of those same places in community with local people.

Cheryl Blosser is a local historian based in New Statesville, Ohio, and a participant in multiple Forest Listening Rooms.



FIG. 13 Shawnee has been home to Harnetty since 2018.

2. Kimmerer, Robin Wall. *Braiding Sweetgrass: Indigenous Wisdom, Scientific Knowledge, and the Teachings of Plants.* Minneapolis: Milkweed Editions, 2013.

REFLECTION

1

Did anything in this conversation stand out to you? Record your impressions here.

2

What is one element of this conversation that you could carry into your own work?

3

What is one element of this conversation that you would change? Why?

Use the blank space below to write, draw, or diagram any remaining thoughts.

4

WORKS CITED

FIG. 6 – 13 Harnetty, Brian "Forest Listening Rooms," workshop, ongoing (Shawnee, OH), http://www.brianharnetty.com/forest-listening-rooms.

QUESTIONS FOR DISCUSSION

How are participants able to shape the content, form, and context of your work? Can you change the work's conditions to include a more expansive definition of community?

How can your work encourage and honor relationships of reciprocity with the living world?

Stewards of the Land

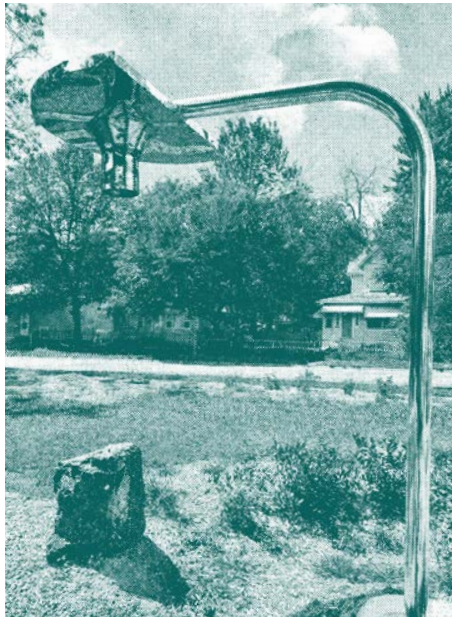


FIG. 14 Rain collection baskets modeled after basketball hoops stand on either side of the court-themed urban farm.

Jordan Weber on Practicing Counter-tactics to Oppression

Through *prototype for poetry vs. rhetoric (deep roots),* Jordan Weber seeks to counter the linked mechanisms of oppression and industrial violence that threaten land and life in communities of color. Through collaboration with, and deep listening to, community members in North Minneapolis, prototype offers space for black, brown and indigenous communities to heal their land, bodies, and spirits.

KA: Could you describe the principles behind *prototype*?

JW: The project meshes food justice with environmental justice, because, as we know, you can't grow healthy food on toxified land. Our BIPOC communities contend with this issue at a much higher rate, because a lot of the facilities and industrial mechanisms in cities are pushed up against brown, Black, and indigenous communities. We intend to counter that.

The function of the site is to have a measurable impact on the community and to shed more light on the really ill work people have already been doing in North Minneapolis, and to honor their decades of activism.

The shape of the work—a basketball court—reflects my identity with blackness in the Midwest, but it's also intended to engage youth on a more immediate basis. My own identification with blackness through basketball makes me hyper-aware of how young black males in inner cities are traditionally tied to the sport. So we built this as an ecology to engage youth in the work, and to make them want to come and ask questions.

We built in spiritual elements as well. Obsidian rocks on both ends of the court act as meditation stoops. Hopefully we'll run courses on meditation and other spiritual tools that can help heal the traumas of being black, brown and indigenous in America. We also use green space to enact that sense of calm and healing that plant life can induce.

KA: You've described prototype as a continuation of the activist tradition in the Midwest. To whom do you pay homage?

JW: Roxane O'Brien is an environmental justice queen chairing the Environmental Quality of Life Committee; she has

done an amazing amount of research on the cancer and asthma rates of the neighborhood. We also honor Juxtaposition Arts—Roger Cummings is one of its co-founders—from which I've been learning alongside various youth programs for a decade now. Roger is kind of a guiding light in the youth activation of the site. Their environmental and racial justice experience has shaped the entirety of the project.

Paying homage to the Dakota, Arapaho, Kickapoo, and Ojibwe indigenous peoples in that region was one of the most important aspects of that work. One way we did this was by making sure they're guiding the plants and medicinal berries that we're putting in the space.

Making inclusivity the focal point, so that everybody's voice and struggle was being heard, made the project go much more smoothly. This also meant being transparent about where funding was coming from, where money was going, and who was getting paid for their time.

KA: How would you describe your role as an artist in prototype?

JW: I think of my role as somebody practicing counter-tactics to extreme oppression. Land stewardship is central to my work; my job as an artist is to reclaim our connection to land so we can heal it and then heal ourselves as well.

KA: What was the process behind prototype?

JW: We spent 6 months organizing with community members, friends, city organizations, Parks and Rec, and environmental justice crews. We organized over 80 meetings to just listen and gain information on what people would want in the neighborhood we were working with. We built relationships through breaking bread, doing tours, and simply talking—you name it, we did it in terms of social interaction. That was the foundation to the entire project.

The process was very fragile, because I'm not from Minneapolis. I wasn't in that community being impacted by the things that I'm trying to counter. Going into those meetings, especially with a large arts institution, put me at risk of misstepping. Making inclusivity the focal point, so that everybody's voice and struggle was being heard, made the project go much more smoothly. This also meant being transparent about where funding was coming from, where money was going, and who was getting paid for their time.

As a biracial person in the Midwest, learning to be accepted by my community has given me a lot of skills that inform the way I relate to the art world. Code-switching between art-speak at an institutional level and being myself around communities is a really interesting portion of my job. On a personal level, if you're not being completely transparent, it can be extremely detrimental. It's important to be sincere and genuine with the people you're talking to, because they can really pick up on if you're in the community for the sake of gain rather than collaboration.

KA: How was the work informed by this extensive meeting process?

JW: When you're talking to many different organizations, patterns in communities become apparent. Thirteen organizations told us that local pollution is coming from this shingles factory and this metal scrapyard. These factories



caused 330% higher rates of lung disease and deaths there than in any other community in Hennepin County. Those patterns directly informed how we focused the project.

For example, that information shaped our choice of plants—I could bore you all day with the species of hyper-accumulator plants that mitigate toxins in the water and the air. We have a rain garden on one side of the basketball court which functions essentially like a mini-wetland: its plants store different carbons from the air and soil in their root systems, reversing some of the effects of pollution. I want to be very clear that this project isn't big enough to pull a lot of these pollutants out; we only have a quarter-acre of land. But it realizes itself in the species of plants in that arena of counter-actions against pollution.



I think of my role as somebody practicing counter-tactics to extreme oppression. Land stewardship is central to my work; my job as an artist is to reclaim our connection to land so we can heal it and then heal ourselves as well.

FIG. 15 – 16 local youth play an integral role in the site's design, construction, and maintenance.

KA: Could you describe Youth Farms' role in shaping the evolution of the project?

JW: Youth Farms, a program for Black and indigenous youth in North Minneapolis, has guided every aspect of the project because they're the ones taking care of it. On a day-to-day basis, Youth Farms are the ones watering and nurturing the plants. They have had a lot of say in the entire process, especially the design and implementation of the food aspects of the garden, which includes 40 raised beds.

It sounds complicated, but it's just a matter of talking to our collaborators face to face. We've had them to the site multiple times and just grilled out, breaking bread, getting to know them, and asking them what they'd like to see. For example, Marcus from Youth Farms had the idea to have these raised beds that look like bleachers. Youth Farms is telling us what they need, how they want us to build up the programming and the direction of the project. Otherwise, I'd have no business being there doing anything.

KA: How do you think the work has shaped collaborators' relationships to one another?

JW: Another role of the artist is to bridge-build between institutions and communities, especially if there are tensions between the two. The artist can foster and build that relationship, both personally and visually. Two of the young cats that have been coming to the project have the cell phone of Nisa Mackie, head of education at the Walker, and that's a life-changing connection that can keep them involved.

KA: What is the significance of *prototype*'s aesthetic element? What sets it apart from a regular urban farm?

JW: There are four or five cats in the community who came by asking why the space was shaped like a basketball court. We told them and they said, 'That's super ill, how can I get involved?' And we were in the position to pay them to help with landscaping and building that project. That's the epitome of success with any social practice project: if you can get the cats involved who were like me — who wouldn't have cared about another urban garden, or who were involved in detrimental ways of life — that can change the direction of a community member's life. That's why artists are crucial.

Jordan Weber is a Des Moines based social sculptor who works alongside communities of color to create green space for healing of social, environmental, and spiritual traumas. He has collaborated with communities across the US, including in Des Moines, IA; St. Louis, MO, and Omaha, NE. You can find more of his work at jordanjweber.com.

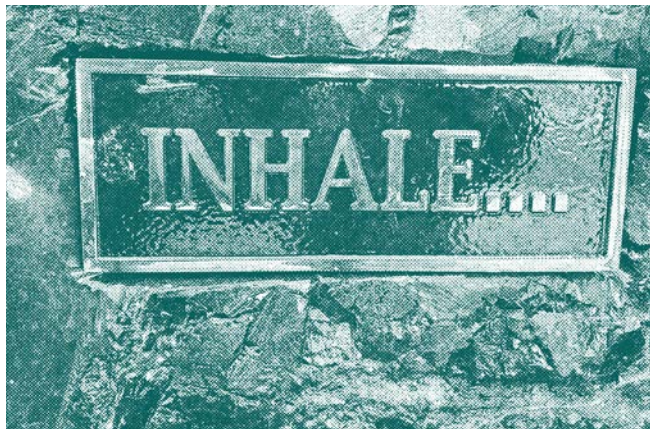


FIG. 17 A detail from one of the farm's meditation stoops.

1

Did anything in this conversation stand out to you? Record your impressions here.

2

What is one element of this conversation that you could carry into your own work?

3

What is one element of this conversation that you would change? Why?

Use the blank space below to write, draw, or diagram any remaining thoughts.

4

QUESTIONS FOR DISCUSSION

How can your listening process invite a broader range of "voices and struggles"?

How can the aesthetic elements of your work be tools for accessibility? For community-building? For healing?

FIG. 14 – 17 Jordan Weber, "prototype for poetry vs. rhetoric," urban farm, ongoing (Walker Art Center, Minneapolis, MN), https://walkerart.org/press-releases/2020/walker-art-center-commissions-new-artwork-in-the-form-of-an-urban-farm

Making Inquiry Your Mission



All photographs courtesy of the Center for Genomic Gastronomy.

The Center for Genomic Gastronomy

"It sounds crazy to build a mission statement around an artistic practice," says Catherine Kramer, cofounder of the Center for Genomic Gastronomy. "But it puts us in touch with ourselves and our goals. Our mission keeps us centered."

The Center for Genomic Gastronomy (CGG), a small, artist-led think tank, has rallied around the same mission statement since its inception. CGG operates in pursuit of alternative culinary futures; by sparking dialogue through participatory harvesting and dining initiatives, the collective asks participants across the globe to imagine, prototype, and discuss ethical, biodiverse food systems.

"We work in dialogue with food systems and the communities that shape them," Kramer explains. "Humans sculpt the planet around our eating habits; as we alter the flow of organisms through our environment, the planet shapes us back. Rather than exploring these networks ourselves, we build scaffoldings for others." To this end, CGG initiatives invite participants to forge their own relationships with food. In *Loci Food Lab,* for example, a food stand journeys to regions around the world. At each stop, communities identify the flora and fauna central to their bioregional food systems, and local chefs serve customized snacks. Through collective exploration of site-specific crops, livestock, and food products, *Food Lab* participants conceive alternative, localized food futures. *Food Lab* becomes a locus of its own: a nerve center for speculation and debate around mindful consumption.



FIG. 18 A crowd gathers outside *Loci Food Lab,* in which local chefs prepare snacks based on surrounding food



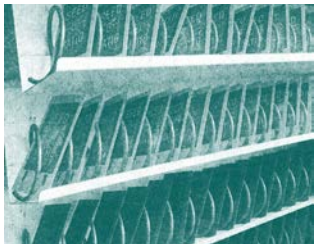


FIG. 19 - 20 packets filled with seeds of cultural, culinary, or geographical significance on offer via *Seed-o-Matic*.

Works like *Food Lab* pose questions, but resist the urge to impose answers. Instead, CGG encourages participants to reach their own conclusions. "We don't antagonize those with certain lines of thinking," Says Kramer. "In fact, we avoid locking horns. At times, for instance, we'll encounter strong resistance to the vegan diet; rather than responding with disquieting facts about meat production, we serve a delicious meatless meal without comment. In doing so, we offer fertile grounds for discovery and conversation." CGG often lets food speak for itself: in Smog Tasting, community groups in polluted areas harvest air in egg foams; bake them into meringues; sample the products; and send the leftovers to local politicians and business owners. Through a series of workshops, *Smog Tasting* empowers participants to model and evaluate the consequences of air pollution and to hold critical figures accountable. *Seed-o-Matic*, a collaboration led by students Emma Conley and Halley Roberts, offers a different means of relating to the environment through food: "the world's slowest vending machine" peddles seeds that participants can plant, cultivate, and savor; encouraging small-scale production, biodiverse consumption, and open access to healthy food choices. *Seed-o-Matic*, like *Smog Tasting* and Food Lab, presents to communities what author and

MAKING INQUIRY YOUR MISSION



FIG. 21 by catching air pollution in egg foams and baking them into meringues, *Smog Tasting* participants gauge the air quality in their area.

activist bell hooks calls 'conscientization'[1]: critical awareness brought about by active engagement. In pursuit of conscientization, CGG sparks inquiry and builds infrastructures for collective exploration. At its best, the think tank cultivates an engaged pedagogy that promotes human relationships to flora, fauna, and the planet that breeds them.

To this ambitious end, CGG adopts a vast and trans-disciplinary practice. "We admire the chameleon," says Kramer. "Who can adapt to different environments and present herself in many contexts." The group

appears at hacker conferences, food fairs, schools, and community centers; and works with specialists, hobbyists, students, and passersby the world over. Their instinctual dabbling broadens their understanding far beyond even the extensive scope of eco art and challenges them to connect, communicate, and empathize with those beyond its echo chamber. Committed multidisciplinarians, Kramer and her ilk esteem art for its diplomatic potential. "As artists, we're able to aestheticize our work," she explains. "We create sensory experiences to intrigue those who would not have been interested otherwise." To reach this wider audience, she adds, the group has begun shifting its attention toward greater accessibility. Of *Food Phreaking,* a journal on food and technology, Kramer says, "We release each issue for open access. Its ethos aligns with that of the open-source movement—we invite others to feed on, remix, and feedback our work."

At its best, CGG cultivates an engaged pedagogy that promotes human relationships to flora, fauna, and the planet that breeds them.



FIG. 22 The fourth issue of *Food Phreaking,* freely available in PDF format.

It must be mentioned that although CGG identifies as an artist-run organization, its roots run deep into the fertile landscape of Molecular Gastronomy, a discipline of food science that considers the culinary arts as a synthesis of three components: social, artistic, and technical. Traditional Molecular Gastronomy concerns itself with the transformation of individual ingredients; CGG views this model through a macro lens, pulling apart entire food networks to evaluate the relations and methods at their core. That its members have little background in food science serves as an impetus to center others in the conversation. *Planetary Sculpture Supper Club,* for instance, entails a series of dinner parties moderated by local chefs, institutions, artists, and educators. Each course feeds into a larger narrative arc: *Supper Club* engagements have illustrated controversies from radiation breeding to de-extinction. Participants gather to dine, discuss, and digest — both literally and figuratively — the topography of today's culinary landscape. *Supper Club* is perhaps the most explicit reflection of CGG's mission: by facilitating communal experiences, the group challenges the human community to improve upon networks of production, consumption, connection, and care. In the decade since its inception, CGG has cultivated and sown new perspectives in regions across the globe, and its table continues to grow.

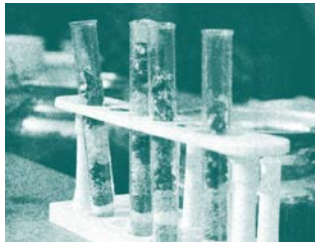


FIG. 23 Vials of seeds and other goodies at a *Planetary Sculpture Supper Club* dinner.



FIG. 24 Guests attend a *Planetary Sculpture Supper Club* event in Bangalore, India

1. bell hooks, "Engaged Pedagogy," in *Teaching to Transgress: Education as the Practice of Freedom* (UK: Routledge, Taylor and Francis Group, 1994), 13 – 22

REFLECTION

1

Did anything in this study stand out to you? Record your impressions here.

2

What is one element of this study that you could carry into your own work? How?

3

What is one element of this study that you would change? Why?

REFLECTION

Use the blank space below to write, draw, or diagram any remaining thoughts.

4

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FIG. 18 Center for Genomic Gastronomy, "Loci Food Lab," performance, 2014-2019 (CGG), https://genomicgastronomy.com/work/2019-2/loci-food-lab/

FIG. 19 Center for Genomic Gastronomy, "Smog Tasting," workshop, 2011 (CGG), https://genomicgastronomy.com/work/2011-2/smog-tasting/

FIG. 20 – 21 Center for Genomic Gastronomy, Conley, Emma, and Roberts, Halley, "Seed-O-Matic," multimedia, 2013 (Center for Genomic Gastronomy), https://genomic-gastronomy.com/work/2013-2/seedomatic/

FIG. 22 Center for Genomic Gastronomy, *Food Phreaking,* publication, 2019 (CGG), https://genomicgastronomy.com/work/2019-2/food-phreaking-issue-04/

FIG. 23 – 24 Center for Genomic Gastronomy & Pereira, Varun, Planetary Sculpture Supper Club Bangalore, ongoing (CGG), https://genomicgastronomy.com/work/2011-2/supper-club-bangalore/.

QUESTIONS FOR DISCUSSION

CGG values cross-disciplinary collaborations with local chefs, producers, and food scientists. If you could work with someone in an industry besides your own, who would you choose? Why?

Imagine a collaboration between CGG and your community. What would be the focus of this project? What kind of work would impact your community most profoundly?

Francesca Fiore; Hillary Wagner; and Syd, Alicia, and Rob Gee



FIG. 25 *SOIL SERIES* participants exploring qualities of the soil and water.

In 2017 Francesca Fiore and Hillary Wagner approached the town of Bethel, Ohio (a return for Wagner, whose family had lived there for generations) with a code of ethics—a commitment to open and collaborative engagement with community members. This code guided the development of *SOIL SERIES: A Social Drawing (SS),* a process of socially engaged research in collaboration with the Bethel community. Through open, adaptive practice, *SOIL SERIES* birthed Bird Closet (BC), an artist collective that served as a "a space for imagination, for an exploration of Bethel, in both its history and its potential for the future." Throughout their work, Francesca, Hillary, and their collaborators insist that deep, vibrant relationships must be the foundation of radical social transformation.

on Transforming Social Imagination

ON TRANSFORMING SOCIAL IMAGINATION

KA: Could you describe the role of relationships in your work?

FF: It was called *SOIL SERIES: A Social Drawing* because each relationship we were building was a mark in a drawing. You're making a line between two people. You're making a mark. Could that be considered a kind of intangible drawing?

HW: We were fascinated by the social infrastructure and resource sharing that existed in Bethel when it was primarily a farming town. If one family owned a tractor and everybody else needed to use it, they would just kind of move it around. We were thinking about that movement, sharing, and all of those relationships. Unfortunately, a lot of the farms have either disappeared or have been consolidated into larger operations. And thus, a lot of the identity of the place and the relationships have fallen apart. We were wondering how social drawing could re-establish some of those relationships.

Centering relationship-building as the artistic practice itself means that the "work" includes sharing resources, collaging, taking care of one another, throwing a birthday party for a Bird Closet member who had never had one, making zines, going to drive-in movies, and playing board games together. Through this process, participants are able not just to develop intimate relationships to one another, but also to imagine how those relationships might ripple out into Bethel as a whole. As BC member Alicia Gee puts it, "Bird Closet is a way to love and support each other, and hopefully do that on a broader scale in our community.

Though their theory of social drawing is related to Joseph Beuys' social sculpture, in which society itself is collaboratively constructed, Hillary and Francesca emphasize that they engage drawing as a medium partly because of its intimate scale, which encourages a focus on building personal, local relationships between people and place.

KA: Can you describe how the work addressed people's relationships to place?

FF: In the community studios, we spent a lot of time feeling around our environments. One day we went down to the creek, pulled up clay, and made pinch pots. It was really about feeling around and digging into the material of the place and establishing these not just conceptual relationships, but also very tactile relationships. Another time we made soil pigments and used them to paint a map of Bethel. When we talked about soil, we talked about how soil shapes the history of a place: the flora and fauna, how people interact with them, the kinds of industry that are present. These questions kept emerging: What is the physical material of this place? How do we relate to it historically and culturally? Can we push around materials and see what happens?

Through this process, participants are able not just to develop intimate relationships to one another, but also to imagine how those relationships might ripple out into Bethel as a whole.

HW: *SOIL SERIES* is as a reference to US soil taxonomy, in which soil is named for the place it's from. We were thinking about the actual soil, the ground we were standing on and how that relates to our identities. The culture that develops in a place can be traced back to the soil that we are standing on. What kinds of things can grow on it? What kind of crops are in the field next door? How does that shape a family structure?

We were also thinking about the environment in terms of the community itself. Over Bird Closet's first summer we were installing artwork on a billboard, wearing our bird masks on the side of a main road. We intentionally disrupted the visual landscape of the community and inserted this strangeness, this poetry. People were honking their horns, yelling out of their windows. Some people pulled over to have a conversation and figure out what we were doing there. The alteration of our environment in that way was one of the exciting parts of the work. I felt that if we were able to stir conversation and inject new types of images into the community, then that could create a puncture where imagination could occur, where we could form new relationships and think about new ways of being in our town.

FF: Our experiments with the land were not separate from putting up the billboard, because it was all about cultivating a deep understanding of place all the way down to the soil. We were trying to understand the landscape, literally, as well as politically and socially. We're trying to go down all those avenues and press on the edges and see where we can puncture through.





FIG. 26 – 27 Bird Closet members assemble a billboard off one of Bethel's main roads.

No matter the radical scope of their imagination, their work was always grounded in Bethel, Ohio with this particular community. As Francesca puts it, BC allowed participants to "look at the world from a fresh perspective and with greater agency. When you're a bird, you're not tethered down by these alienating forces. Inhabiting the birds allowed us to break out of those strictures. It's not that we ever left Bethel when we were imagining this other universe, but rather that we

were able to embody different potentialities through the birds."In his treatise The Aesthetic Dimension, Herbert Marcuse writes that art can "shatter everyday experience and anticipate another reality principle," not by ignoring material realities, but by "transfiguring" those realities. Francesca echoes this view of art's revolutionary potential when describing the collages BC creates: "taking material apart and reimagining it as we put it back together." By shifting scale to deeply interrogate the material of Bethel, their work created space to transform it.

Talking with Francesca and Hillary, I was struck by their insistence on coming into the work with more questions than answers. Rather than entering Bethel with a set of goals or structures, they entered with a code of ethics, which committed them to horizontal and collaborative engagement—leading them to "follow the ways that the community was moving."

KA: Could you speak more on how you are able to follow the community in your work?

HW: One of our first real steps of passing over control was during the *Community Studios* exhibition. We invited the teenagers we were working with to be co-curators and make decisions about where the artwork should go in the barn. Because of that relationship, many of those teenagers went on to become Bird Closet members.

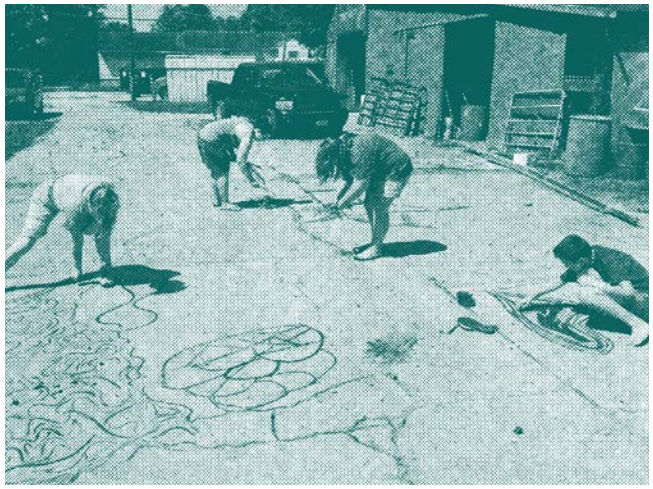


FIG. 28 *SOIL SERIES* participants creatively engaging Bethel's "materials".

FF: Bird Closet is the closest we've come to we've come to fully seeing our authorship dissolve. Part of the reason it works so well is because from day one we established that this is everyone's space. A lot of the planning and a lot of the ideating and creating of the space itself was done collaboratively. Being able to relinquish that control is not always comfortable. There have been moments of discomfort where I have not agreed with what the group decided. But everyone's voice has equal weight—from 16-year-olds to ourselves who have MFAs.

KA: Could you describe the creation of Bird Closet?

Syd Gee: I knew that young artists in Bethel needed a community who would love them and see them as themselves. I brought my friends over, and this moment of connection sparked an idea that this collective could actually happen.

FF: The name Bird Closet started as sort of an inside joke. We had facilitated discussions about artist collectives like the Guerilla Girls as well as Afrofuturist creatives who embodied otherworldly personas and imagined the future in order to interrogate the present. One of the members suggested, well, why don't we all become birds? Why don't we all pick a bird alter ego? It quickly evolved into, let's make masks so that we can inhabit those bird personas. And what kinds of birds are we going to choose? We're going to choose birds native to the area because we're talking about place. So we established this mythology within the collective.

KA: How did you build infrastructure to allow members to allow the work to carry on beyond the scope of your facilitation?

FF: It all goes back to our commitment to responsiveness and flexibility. This infrastructure created itself because there was this openness to responding to what was needed

at any given moment. Bird Closet continues to shift and is completely different from what it looked like in the beginning. It is an organism, it is adapting.

HW: We've felt for a long time that the work is making itself; it has its own way of moving that we're just following.

FF: There have been moments where it hasn't felt that way, where we felt like we were dragging it along. And those moments were important too, because they showed us that something was wrong. Again, that has to do with listening to the work and what is needed.

By listening to the community's needs in each moment, Bird Closet is able to straddle seemingly polar axes: speculating brilliant futures while building radical bonds of love and community in the present. It's why, when I asked Syd Gee to describe BC, she called it "both a piece of art and a family that creates art."

KA: Could you discuss how your work balances tangible change in the present with speculative imagination for the future?

FF: I see capitalism as a crisis of imagination in a lot of ways. One way to resist that alienation is through radical imagination. No, we did not solve food insecurity in Bethel, nor did we have the resources to do that. But we might have the ability to imagine possibilities for that, or to imagine alternative systems for sharing resources. For example, there have been debates over whether a community garden—which seems so mundane—would be possible at all in Bethel. We realized that we had to start not in building a greenhouse to support hydroponic farming for tackling food insecurity—but in just imagining that possibility. Establishing pathways to imagination is so necessary in creating actual material change.

HW: Bird Closet came into existence because the crisis was in the imagination to start with. We needed this other universe where we could imagine new possibilities and share them with the community. Francesca and I wanted to solve problems and build models for social change, but ideas kept getting lost in translation. We needed images and poetry to build out our understanding of the future; we had to start there first.

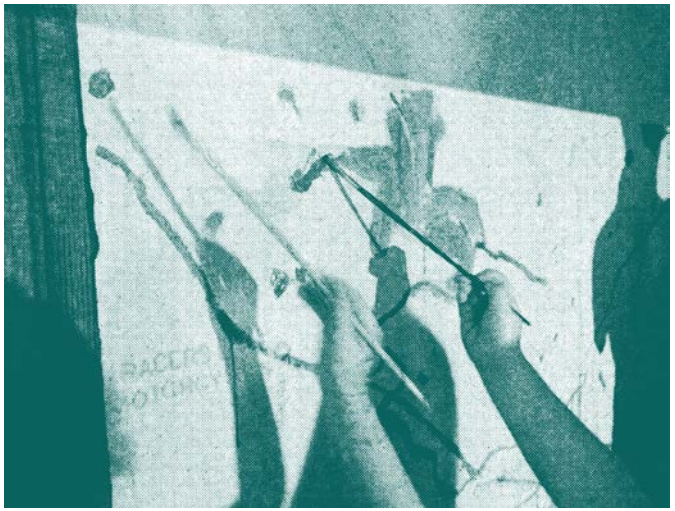


FIG. 29 Building relationships through collective markmaking

Francesca Fiore is a Philadelphia-based artist and professor of visual art whose work explores collectivity, intimacy, and memory through process-based and relational practice. Hillary Wagner is a Cincinnati-based artist engaging materiality, place, memory and stewardship.

Sydney, Alicia, and Rob Gee are Bird Closet members and lifelong residents of Bethel, Ohio. Sydney is a student at Antioch College.

3. Marcuse, Herbert. The Aesthetic Dimension. Boston: Beacon Press Books, 1978.

REFLECTION

1

Did anything in this conversation stand out to you? Record your impressions here.

2

What is one element of this conversation that you could carry into your own work?

3

What is one element of this conversation that you would change? Why?

Use the blank space below to write, draw, or diagram any remaining thoughts.

4

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FIG. 25, 28 – 29 Bird Closet, "Bird Closet," collective, ongoing (Bethel, OH), https://www.birdcloset.com/

FIG. 26 – 27 Fiore, Francesca, and Hillary Wagner, "SOIL Series: A Social Drawing," collective, 2017-2019 (Bethel, OH), https://soilseriesbethel.com/

QUESTIONS FOR DISCUSSION

How can you lay a foundation in your work for collaborators to take ownership? What ideas about the work or the community might you have to relinquish in this process?

Is relationship building embedded into your work? How can you build in time and space to strengthen relationships? How can you be present to support your collaborators?

Practices: An In-Progress List

ORGANIZERS' NOTE:

Whether you're beginning to envision possibilities for your community, or reflecting on an existing collaboration, you can use this toolkit to challenge, articulate, or re-center your understanding of community-driven practice. The practices below are not definitions, but jumping off points for exploration, contestation, and dialogue.

We invite you to respond to these prompts in conversation, writing, photo documentation, movement, or any form of expression that feels comfortable to you. Nor is this list exhaustive—we hope that it will only grow, and we wish you clarity as you build your own.

01 Ambiguity

02 Commonism

03 Continuity

04 Dialogue

05 Determination

06 Dissonance

07 Gathering

08 Grounding

09 Mission

10 Mutualism

AMBIGUITY

Moments of disorientation create space for unpredictable discovery. How can you challenge existing narratives, leave questions unanswered, and introduce new lines of inquiry? Through open-ended practice, how can you create conditions that scaffold communal discovery? How can you begin with questions rather than answers?

CALL TO ACTION List the conditions that define your project — these can be locations, resources, abilities, processes, prompts, participants, or anything else that affects the outcome of your work. Of each, ask, what alternative outcomes might you encourage without this restriction? Can you broaden the realm of possibility without compromising your intended goals?

CONDITION

INTENTION

Cross out at least one condition on your list.

COMMONISM

Collaborative thinking breeds collaborative ownership. If you reject the idea of individual responsibility, your work can grow larger than the sum of your contributions. How might you organize horizontally? Rather than creating roles for participants to fill, how can your culture and infrastructure invite each collaborator to co-create the work?

CALL TO ACTION As a group, note:

Why do you trust each other to contribute to this work in a meaningful way?

Moving forward, how might you deepen and amplify that trust?

How would you prefer to be held accountable for your contribution to this work?

Who among you is directly affected by the problem at hand, and how might you center them in the search for a solution?

CONTINUITY

Our work is a continuation, not a beginning nor an end. Works may blossom and expand into new forms, iterations, networks, ecosystems, and communities. What ongoing networks of knowledge, care, and relationship exist here? How can you enact a long-term commitment to these networks? Through documentation and sustainable leadership, how might you build relationships and infrastructures for ongoing action?

CALL TO ACTION The dot on this page represents your project. Around it, build a rhizome of cause and effect. Towards the left side of the page, write, sketch, or diagram the circumstances that preceded ours. On the right, document those that might follow.

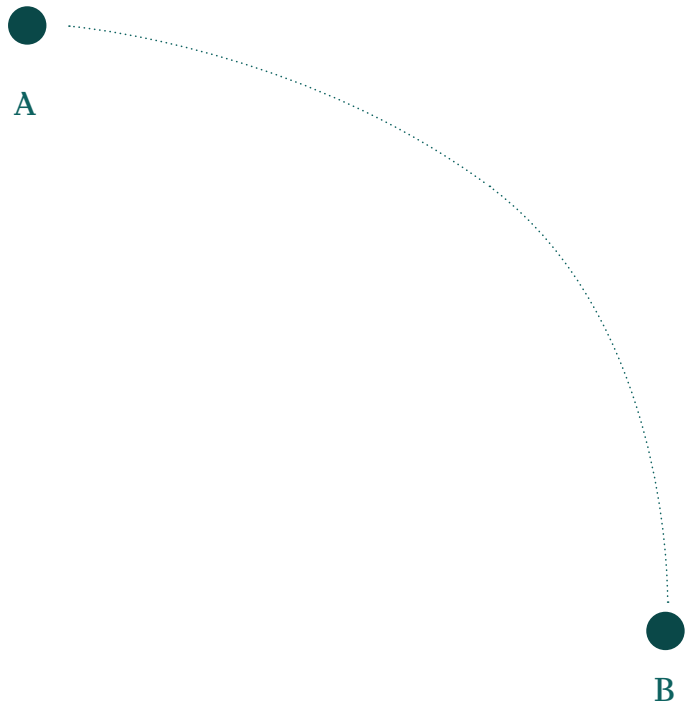


How might this project impact the community in six months? In fifty years? In one hundred?

DETERMINATION

Working from a state of determination compels you to push forwards and claim accountability for the outcome of your efforts. It represents faith in your collective action. How does your relationship to the environment inspire you to act? What are you determined to do?

CALL TO ACTION Point A on this page represents your project. Label point B with one goal you hope to achieve. Consider: the line between these dots represents the action that will fulfill your goal. What must you determine to do? Label the line accordingly.



Once you've finished, draw and connect more dots. Make sure to label each line.

DIALOGUE

What does collective exploration look like? How can learning become a dialogue or interchange? How can we all be empowered to learn, to teach, and to act?

CALL TO ACTION Choose one skill, craft, or field of knowledge required in your project. How might you develop this knowledge as a collective? Instead of writing an explanation, organize a discussion. Instead of creating a tutorial, design a workshop. Complete this statement of intent:

To facilitate collective inquiry about .....

.....,

We can engage in .....

.....

.....

Together, we'll explore .....

.....

.....

.....

.....

by asking: .....

.....

.....?

To do so, we'll need .....

.....

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.....

Even as you seek to teach, ask: how might you learn?

DISSONANCE

Stay with the trouble. Being together radically means pushing at the boundaries of what it means to be part of a community. Can discord and disagreement be beginnings rather than endings? Can a community include people who do not already identify with each other? Can it move beyond the human to include other elements of the natural world?

CALL TO ACTION Participate in a group discussion without saying 'no' or 'know.' Ask, "Why?" Say, "Tell me more." Through collaborative discourse, question statements to hone in on commonly held truths. Consider these cues if:

YOU DISAGREE	Ask, "I'd love learn more about why you think that." Learn about the speaker's approach, experience, and knowledge.
YOU HAVE A COUNTERPOINT	Say, "keeping your thoughts in mind, I'd like to offer a different idea." Share the observations that inform your opinion. Ask your collaborators for their thoughts.
YOU'D LIKE TO INTERRUPT	Use the space below to write down your pressing thoughts. Later, when it's your turn to speak, say, "I'd like to return to..."

Focus on collaborators most affected by the problems at hand — their understanding will lay the groundwork for informed solutions.

GATHERING

When you gather — whether virtually, physically, or symbolically — you lend weight and volume to the abstract notion of solidarity and collaboration. Where might you find togetherness? How does space allow you to acknowledge, confirm, or strengthen your work?

CALL TO ACTION Map the spatial existence of your project. Does it exist across internet platforms? In a particular neighborhood? In the dispersal of material? Mark spaces for gathering, for interchange, for demonstration, and for distribution. Mark where the project will live on for future participants.

Don't worry about scale.

GROUNDING

While you might have visions of utopia, it's worth remembering that a utopia is literally a no-place. How can your work be grounded in place—building deep roots within specific communities? How can your work honor different ways of knowing a place? How can you reject the dominant boundaries of the audience according to race, class, and other factors? How are you actively seeking to make your work accessible to a specific audience?

CALL TO ACTION Spend a few days at a space central to your community, whether it be a local library, a community garden, or an online forum. Then ask,

How long have you been a part of this community?

How have you been transformed by this community?

To whom in this community do you consider yourselves accountable?

Reflect on your answers. How might you restructure your project to reflect these insights?

MISSION

By developing a collective mission statement, you can center your goals rather than any individual actors. How might a mission-driven practice encourage consensus, consistency, and impact? How might your mission inform the way you work?

CALL TO ACTION As a collective, use the space below to reflect on your shared goals, your intended approaches, and your communal strengths.

Then, fill in the blanks in this passage:

We are .....

.....

.....

Through .....

.....

and .....

.....,

we work to .....

.....

.....

.....

Ask, how does your work already reflect this mission?
What else does your mission ask of you?

MUTUALISM

By working alongside your communities and ecosystems, you can honor existing groundwork, networks, systems, and infrastructures. Rather than serving other humans, creatures, and bioregions, you can work alongside them to reach collectively held goals. What are your collaborators working towards? How might working together further their mission?

CALL TO ACTION Use the space below to reflect on your project. You can write, draw, paste, or diagram: use any medium that feels comfortable to you.

Replace renderings of service with those of collaboration. For example, Let FOR become WITH, let ASK become TRUST, and let ALLOW become EMPOWER.

Then, ask: how might you evolve your project to reflect this language?

DISCUSSION SPACE

USE THESE PAGES TO REFLECT, PLAN, NOTE, AND DIAGRAM

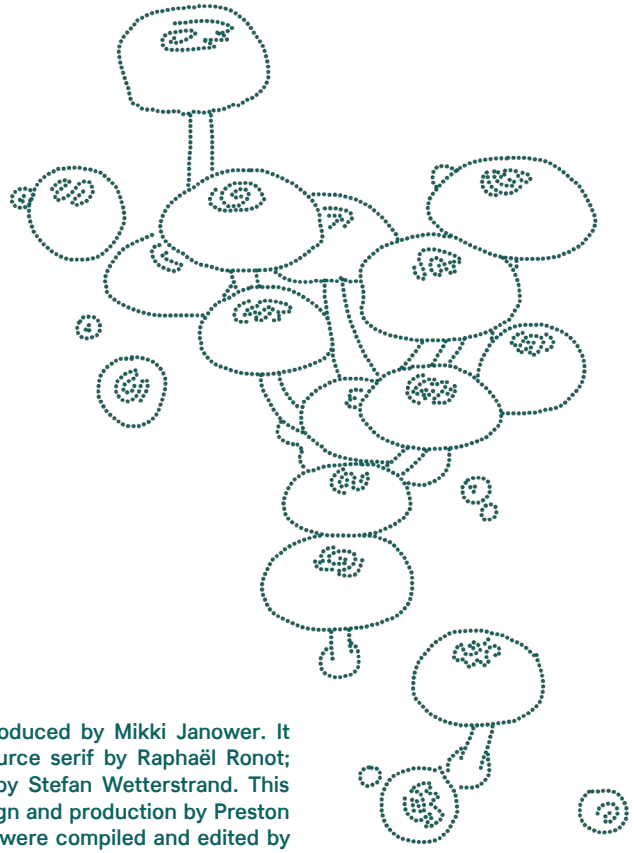
USE THESE PAGES TO REFLECT, PLAN, NOTE, AND DIAGRAM

DISCUSSION SPACE

USE THESE PAGES TO REFLECT, PLAN, NOTE, AND DIAGRAM

USE THESE PAGES TO REFLECT, PLAN, NOTE, AND DIAGRAM

We've organized this toolkit from the ancestral and contemporary lands of the Potawatomi, Taos, Pawtucket, and Munsie Lenape people. We are grateful for the conversations we've had with the places, people and creatures we've met here.



This booklet was designed and produced by Mikki Janower. It is typeset in Minipax, an open-source serif by Raphaël Ronot; and Lunchtype, a free sans serif by Stefan Wetterstrand. This project exists online thanks to design and production by Preston Thompson, and its audio elements were compiled and edited by Kanyinsola Anifowoshe.

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The conversations in this book have been edited and condensed for clarity.

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A COMMUNITY IS A GARDEN

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